

DIGITALAIKART
PREMIUM EXAM HANDBOOKS

CUET UG 2027

The Starter Handbook

India's biggest university entrance exam,
decoded for the 2026-27 season

15.68 lakh

registered in 2026

37

subjects, pick up to 5

275+

universities accept it

Verified against NTA, DU and university official records - September 2026

Digital Edition - First Edition

Read This First

One Exam, Most of India's Universities

If you are in Class 12 (or repeating the year) and you want a seat at Delhi University, BHU, JNU, Jamia Millia Islamia, AMU, or almost any central university - and a growing list of over 275 state, deemed and private universities - there is exactly one exam that decides it: the Common University Entrance Test, CUET (UG).

In 2026, 15,68,866 candidates registered for it. That made CUET UG one of the largest computer-based exams in the world, and comfortably India's second-biggest entrance exam after JEE Main. It replaced board-marks admissions at central universities in 2022, and every year since, the queue has grown: 13.48 lakh in 2024, 13.55 lakh in 2025, 15.69 lakh in 2026.

Yet most students preparing for it are preparing blind. They start in January, when registration opens - four months before the exam - instead of in September, when the smart money starts. They pick subjects first and check course requirements later, discovering in May that their combination locks them out of the programme they wanted. They treat the General Aptitude Test - the one paper with no board-exam overlap - as a last-week afterthought.

This handbook exists to fix that. It is the starter kit for CUET UG 2027: the exam decoded question by question, every official rule in plain numbers, the full 37-subject menu, a method for choosing your five subjects, the September-to-May runway, and the part after the exam that nobody teaches - how a score becomes a seat through Delhi University's CSAS and each university's own counselling.

15,68,866

candidates registered for CUET UG
2026 (NTA)

11,64,098

candidates appeared in CUET UG 2026
(NTA)

2,14,167

more registrations than 2025 (NTA)

How to use this book

Chapters 1-8 decode the exam machine: what it is, who runs it, what it costs, how it is scored. Chapters 9-19 cover preparation: the domain spotlights, the General Aptitude Test, the boards overlap, and the month-by-month runway. Chapters 20-25 cover what happens after you walk out of the test centre. Every fact was verified in September 2026 against NTA, Delhi University and university records. Where a 2027 date was not yet announced, it is marked expected, with the 2026 pattern it follows. This is a starter handbook - it organises your preparation; it is not a substitute for NCERT textbooks and question banks.

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A note on what is verified and what is expected

CUET UG 2027's official information bulletin had not been released when this handbook went to press. All rules, fees and dates from the 2026 cycle are stated as the 2026 position and are the base for 2027 expectations. The 2027 bulletin - expected around January 2027 on cuet.nta.nic.in - is the final word. Check it the day it drops; every year it contains small changes that sink unprepared candidates.

CHAPTER 1

The Exam 15.7 Lakh Students Cannot Skip

CUET replaced the board-marks lottery with one common test - and the queue keeps growing.

Before 2022, admission to Delhi University meant praying your Class 12 percentage crossed an arbitrary cutoff - 99.25% for some colleges, literally. A student in a Kerala board with 94% had no fair way to compete with a student in a Delhi board with 96%, because boards differ in difficulty, generosity and grading. The Ministry of Education's answer was the Common University Entrance Test: one exam, one syllabus base (NCERT), one scoring scale, for every candidate in the country.

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has run CUET (UG) every year since 2022. Every central university now admits its undergraduate students through it, and a fast-growing list of state, deemed and private universities accepts its scores too. In 2026, over 270 universities used CUET scores - roughly 50 central, 36 state, 23-25 deemed, more than 150 private and government institutions combined.

The scale tells you what kind of race this is

NTA's own press releases give the numbers for 2026: 15,68,866 unique candidates registered; the exam ran across 868 centres in 321 cities in India plus 15 international cities; 19 examination days and 35 shifts; 332 question papers administered and 18,160 questions in total. Of the registered candidates, 11,64,098 appeared. Roughly 43% of all registrations came from just three regions - Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Delhi.

Year	Unique registrations	What it means
2024	13,47,820	Third year of CUET; growth flattening
2025	13,54,699	Almost flat - critics called peak CUET
2026	15,68,866	A 2.14 lakh jump; CUET's biggest year yet

Read that table the way a strategist would: the flat 2025 was a pause, not a ceiling. More universities join the CUET fold every year, and each new state or private university that accepts the score converts thousands of local applicants into CUET candidates. Expect 2027 to set another record.

Why this changes how you should prepare

A 15.7 lakh-candidate exam with a common syllabus base rewards a different kind of preparation than board exams do. The questions are MCQs with negative marking, not descriptive answers. The syllabus is NCERT - the books you already study in school - but the format punishes half-knowledge. And one paper, the General Aptitude Test, has no board equivalent at all, which is precisely why it decides so many ranks: everyone starts it at zero, and most students start it too late.

The one-sentence summary of this book

Start now, in September; pick subjects against course requirements, not habit; treat NCERT as the syllabus and MCQ practice as the sport; give the General Aptitude Test its own weekly hours; and register in January without a single mistake in the form.

CHAPTER 2

What CUET Actually Is - and Is Not

One exam, three kinds of papers, and a hard wall between the test and the admission.

The three moving parts

- **NTA conducts the exam.** The National Testing Agency, under the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, runs registration, the test, answer keys, challenges and the result. It publishes an Information Bulletin each cycle that is the rulebook for everything in this chapter.
- **Universities decide admissions.** NTA only delivers scores. Each participating university runs its own admission process - eligibility, seat matrix, reservations, merit lists and counselling - using those scores. The University of Delhi, for example, runs its Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS); BHU and others run their own portals.
- **The score is a currency.** One CUET score can be spent at 275+ universities in the same season, which is why subject choice (Chapter 7) is a portfolio decision, not a single-course decision.

What CUET is not

- It is not a board exam replacement. You still need your Class 12 pass; many universities add their own minimum percentage in the qualifying exam for specific programmes.
- It is not an aptitude exam like an IQ test. Two of its three paper types (languages and domain subjects) are knowledge tests drawn from the NCERT syllabus you can study.
- It is not one national counselling. There is no JoSAA-equivalent; after the result you apply separately to each university you want, on its own portal, on its own schedule (Chapters 21-22).

Who accepts the score in 2027

The participating list is dynamic - NTA maintains it at cuet.nta.nic.in and updates it through the year. As of September 2026, for the 2027 cycle, around 275 universities were listed: about 49-50 central universities (every central university admits through CUET), roughly 36 state universities, around 25-30 deemed universities, over 120 private universities, and five other government institutions. The names that move most of the demand: University of Delhi, Banaras Hindu University, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Jamia Millia Islamia, Aligarh Muslim University, University of Allahabad, Tezpur University, Hyderabad Central University, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar University Delhi, and Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University - plus state names like Delhi Technological University and Devi Ahilya Vishwavidyalaya, and private names like Ashoka, Chandigarh and Sharda.

Before you shortlist, bookmark one page

cuet.nta.nic.in lists every participating university with its programme-specific subject mapping and seat matrix. Chapter 7 turns that page into your subject-selection method. Universities also publish Bulletin of Information documents each cycle - Delhi University's runs to dozens of pages and is worth reading once, end to end.

CHAPTER 3

The 2027 Calendar, Anchored to 2026

The 2027 bulletin is not out. The 2026 rhythm tells you when everything will happen.

NTA announces the CUET UG calendar in the Information Bulletin, published when registration opens. For 2026 that was 3 January 2026 - the form went live the same day. If 2027 follows the same rhythm (it has, three years running), here is your year at a glance. Treat the dates in the right column as planning anchors, not promises.

Stage	What happened in 2026	What to expect for 2027
Registration opens	3 January 2026 (bulletin released same day)	Early January 2027
Registration closes	30 January, extended into early February	Late January / early February 2027
Fee payment deadline	31 January (extended to 7 February)	A few days after the form closes
Correction window	2-4 February	Early February 2027
Exam city announcement	April-May	April-May 2027
Admit cards	5 May (for the first phase)	About a week before your first paper
The exam	11-31 May 2026 (with 6-7 June reschedules)	May 2027, multi-week window
Answer key + challenges	June (displayed with recorded responses)	June 2027
Result	23 June 2026	Late June 2027
University admissions	DU CSAS opened 27 June; classes 21 July	Late June onwards, per university

Two structural facts matter more than any single date. First, CUET 2026 ran across a three-week window (11-31 May) with 19 examination days and 35 shifts - your papers may be spread across several days, and the exam window can spill into early June for reschedules, as it did in 2026. Second, the result comes about three weeks after the last paper, and university counselling starts almost immediately - Delhi University's CSAS portal opened within days of the result. Your paperwork (certificates, category documents, photos) must be ready before June, not assembled in the last week.

The September vantage point

From today (September 2026) to the expected May 2027 exam you have roughly eight months - the full runway this book's plan in Chapter 17 is built around. Registration is four months away. That is enough time to finish the NCERT base twice and run 25+ mocks; it is also short enough that every weekend you defer the General Aptitude Test now costs you a topic later.

CHAPTER 4

Who Can Sit: Eligibility Rules

NTA's gate is wide. Individual universities narrow it - and that is where candidates get rejected.

The NTA-level rules (2026 position)

- **Qualifying exam:** you must have passed Class 12 (or an equivalent exam from a recognised board), or be appearing in it in 2027. There is no minimum percentage at the NTA level.
- **No age limit.** NTA imposes none for appearing in CUET (UG). Repeaters and gap-year candidates sit openly.
- **Subject freedom:** you may choose your CUET subjects irrespective of what you studied in Class 12 - the bulletin says so explicitly. The catch is in the next paragraph.

The university-level gate (where careers actually break)

Each university sets its own eligibility per programme: which CUET subject combination it demands, any minimum Class 12 marks in specific subjects, age rules for a few programmes, and its own reservations. Delhi University computes programme-specific merit from defined combinations of your CUET papers and also applies its qualifying exam rules; professional programmes elsewhere can demand both a subject combination and a minimum board percentage. A brilliant CUET score in the wrong combination scores zero at the admissions desk. This is the single most common self-inflicted failure in CUET - and it is entirely avoidable if you choose subjects the way Chapter 7 tells you to.

Documents to keep ready by December

- Class 10 and 12 marksheets (or the school's bonafide for appearing candidates)
- Aadhaar-linked mobile number and a personal email (NTA communicates only on the contacts in the form)
- Recent passport photo and signature in the specified sizes
- Category certificate in the central-list format if you claim OBC-NCL, EWS, SC, ST or PwBD
- Domicile or other documents your target universities demand (check their bulletins, not just NTA's)

The PwBD rule worth knowing

Candidates with a certified benchmark disability get compensatory time of 20 minutes per hour of examination, and a scribe facility is available for eligible candidates - both are in the official bulletin, on request, with the forms filed in advance. If this applies to you, register the scribe details on the portal early, not in May.

CHAPTER 5

The Exam, Question by Question

Every number in the 2026 pattern, in one place - because strategy is downstream of format.

Parameter	CUET UG 2026 rule
Mode	Computer-based test (CBT) at a test centre
Subjects offered	37 = 13 languages + 23 domain subjects + 1 General Aptitude Test
Your selection	Up to 5 subjects (including languages and GAT)
Questions per paper	50, and all of them are compulsory
Duration per paper	60 minutes
Marking	+5 for correct, -1 for incorrect, 0 for unattempted
Maximum per paper	250 marks (50 x 5)
Mediums	13: English, Hindi, Assamese, Bengali, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, Tamil, Telugu, Urdu
Shifts	Multiple shifts, depending on candidate numbers and subject combinations
PwBD compensatory time	20 minutes per hour of examination

Four consequences of these numbers

- **72 seconds per question.** 60 minutes for 50 questions means the clock, not the syllabus, is the real opponent. Speed is a trained skill (Chapter 19), not an inheritance.
- **Compulsory means compulsory.** With no internal choice, you cannot skip a hard question and make it up elsewhere in the paper - you can only skip it strategically (Chapter 15 shows when skipping beats guessing).
- **250-mark papers, not percentages.** Universities combine your paper scores per their own formulas. A 200 in Physics and 180 in Chemistry are different currencies depending on the programme's merit rule.
- **Five slots, one portfolio.** With up to 5 subjects, a well-chosen combination can unlock courses across multiple universities simultaneously - and a lazy one can lock every door.

What the test centre looks like

The 2026 exam ran in 868 centres across 321 Indian cities plus 15 international ones. The interface shows one question at a time with options you select by click; there is a timer, a question palette showing answered, unanswered and marked-for-review states, and a submit button with confirmation. Roughly 96.6% of 2026 candidates were allotted one of their preferred exam cities, and 79% got their first choice - but with 43% of demand concentrated in UP, Bihar and Delhi, popular cities fill; the portal then offers reallocation into vacant cities. Fill your city preferences honestly, first to last.

Do this once, free, before December

NTA provides mock tests on its portals and maintains the National Testing Abhyas app for daily practice; SATHEE CUET (sathee.iitk.ac.in), a Government of India free-preparation platform built with IITs, offers CUET-specific practice. Sitting one full 60-minute computer mock before you plan your study schedule tells you more about your speed gap than a month of self-assessment.

CHAPTER 6**The 37 Subjects on the Menu**

The complete official 2026 list, with codes - because the form asks for codes, not names.

The 2026 list is the best predictor of the 2027 menu. It is much shorter than pre-2026 years: NTA trimmed the menu to 37 subjects, discontinuing several domain subjects (including Entrepreneurship, Teaching Aptitude, Fashion Studies, Tourism, Legal Studies and Engineering Graphics) and most foreign languages. If you were advised to take one of those from an outdated source, that advice is a year stale.

The 13 languages (Section I)

Code	Language	Code	Language	Code	Language
101	English	106	Kannada	111	Tamil
102	Hindi	107	Malayalam	112	Telugu
103	Assamese	108	Marathi	113	Urdu
104	Bengali	109	Odia		
105	Gujarati	110	Punjabi		

The 23 domain subjects (Section II)

Code	Subject	Code	Subject
301	Accountancy / Book-Keeping	316	Knowledge Tradition-Practices in India
302	Agriculture	318	Mass Media / Mass Communication
303	Anthropology	319	Mathematics / Applied Mathematics
304	Biology / Biological Science / Biotechnology / Biochemistry	320	Performing Arts (Dance, Drama, Music)
305	Business Studies	321	Physical Education (Yoga, Sports)
306	Chemistry	322	Physics
307	Environmental Science	323	Political Science
308	Computer Science / Information Practices	324	Psychology
309	Economics / Business Economics	325	Sanskrit
312	Fine Arts / Visual Arts / Commercial Arts	326	Sociology
313	Geography / Geology		
314	History		
315	Home Science		

The aptitude paper (Section III)

Code 501: the General Aptitude Test (GAT) - in 2026 the only aptitude paper on the menu. Its full syllabus and preparation plan get a chapter of their own (Chapter 10), because it is the one paper every serious candidate takes and almost nobody prepares systematically.

13

languages (Codes 101-113)

23

domain subjects (Codes 301-326)

1

General Aptitude Test (Code 501)

A quiet trap in the fine print

Several domain codes bundle families of subjects - 304 covers Biology, Biological Science, Biotechnology and Biochemistry; 319 covers Mathematics and Applied Mathematics. University course mappings name one member of the family. When a DU programme asks for Mathematics, code 319 satisfies it - but check the university's mapping document for how it treats the bundle, and never assume two members of a bundle are interchangeable for a specific course.

CHAPTER 7

Choosing Your Five Subjects

The most marks-affecting decision of your CUET season - made in one evening, correctly.

NTA lets you take up to five subjects - a language, domain subjects, and the GAT - and it explicitly allows you to choose subjects you did not study in Class 12. But universities map courses to specific subject combinations, and the mapping is stricter than the exam. Choosing your five is therefore a portfolio exercise: you are covering your target courses across several universities with five papers, no more.

The method, in five steps

- 1 Write your target courses first** - not colleges, courses. B.Com (Hons), BA (Hons) Economics, B.Sc (Hons) Physics, BA LLB, BCA, B.Sc Agriculture: each has its own subject demand somewhere.
- 2 Pull the mapping for each course** from cuet.nta.nic.in's participating-universities section and each university's Bulletin of Information. Every participating university publishes which CUET papers unlock which programme.
- 3 Build a grid:** courses down the side, required subjects across the top. The subjects that cover the most target courses are your core papers.
- 4 Add your language** - English or Hindi or another of the 13 - checking whether your target programmes map a specific language paper or accept any.
- 5 Fill the last slot with GAT** unless a target course demands a specific domain subject instead. Many programmes (including those whose old domain subjects were discontinued in 2026) admit on the GAT.

What combinations typically look like (2026 mappings)

If you want	Typical CUET combination
B.Com (Hons) at DU	English + a second language or GAT + Accountancy/Business Studies/Economics/Mathematics (per the course's mapping)
BA (Hons) Economics	English + Mathematics + one or two more per the university's rule
B.Sc (Hons) Physics/Chemistry	Language + Physics + Chemistry + Mathematics (or the university's exact demand)
B.Sc Agriculture (BHU and others)	Physics + Chemistry + Biology/Mathematics per the university's mapping, plus language/GAT
BA (Hons) Humanities programmes	Language + relevant domain (History, Political Science, Sociology, Psychology, etc.) + GAT
Programmes whose old domain papers were dropped	General Aptitude Test based merit, per the university's 2026+ mapping

The table above is a pattern, not a rulebook

There is no single national mapping. Delhi University's B.Com (Hons) combination is defined in its Bulletin of Information; BHU's B.Sc Agriculture demand sits in BHU's own admission rules. Treat Chapter 7's grid method as the deliverable - build it from the current-year bulletins in September, then re-verify when the 2027 bulletins arrive in January. Mappings do change year to year.

Five mistakes that waste exam slots

- Choosing subjects because they were easy in school, then discovering the target course never accepted them.
- Assuming domain subjects must match your board stream - NTA allows otherwise; only the university's mapping matters.
- Skipping the GAT because it feels optional - for many courses it is the second scoring paper, and for some the only merit basis.
- Deciding in January under form-deadline pressure instead of in September with a clear head.
- Taking all five subjects from one narrow cluster, leaving no language or no GAT, and shrinking your university options to one.

How many subjects should you actually take?

Fee rises per additional subject beyond three, but the real cost is preparation depth. Five subjects done well beat five done thin, and three excellent papers beat four mediocre ones for most course mappings. The honest rule: take the four or five that your target-course grid genuinely requires, and not one more for prestige. Every extra paper adds a 250-mark exam you must prepare, sit and survive in a three-week window.

CHAPTER 8

What Each Paper Actually Tests

The official syllabus statements, translated into a study directive.

Language papers (Section I)

Per the 2026 bulletin, language is tested through **reading comprehension** (based on different types of passages - factual, literary and narrative), **literary aptitude** and **vocabulary**. There is no literature syllabus to memorise. The preparation directive is exposure: daily reading across genres, timed passage practice, vocabulary built by context rather than word lists. In 2026, English was the most-chosen subject in the entire exam - which means the marking in it is dense and the paper separates candidates on comprehension speed, not on knowing obscure words.

Domain papers (Section II)

The bulletin is blunt: domain subjects follow **the NCERT syllabus**. That single line carries the whole preparation economy of CUET - the Class 12 NCERT textbook for each domain subject is the primary source, and the exam tests it in MCQ form: application, fact recall, diagrams, numericals and assertion-style logic drawn from NCERT concepts. Chapter 16 shows how to make board study and domain-paper study the same work.

The General Aptitude Test (Section III)

The GAT's official syllabus statement, verbatim topics: **general knowledge**, **current affairs**, **general mental ability**, **numerical ability**, **quantitative reasoning** (simple application of basic mathematical concepts - arithmetic, algebra, geometry, mensuration, statistics) and **logical and analytical reasoning**. No NCERT chapter covers that list. It is a habits paper - daily current affairs, drilled mental arithmetic, and worked reasoning sets - and it gets its own playbook in Chapter 10.

Paper type	Official syllabus base	How it is scored into merit
Language (13 offered)	RC: factual, literary, narrative passages; literary aptitude; vocabulary	Combined per each university's programme formula
Domain (23 offered)	NCERT (Class 12) syllabus for the subject	Programme-specific combinations defined by each university
GAT	GK, current affairs, mental ability, numerical ability, quantitative reasoning, logical/analytical reasoning	Standalone merit for many programmes; second paper for most others

The question style, in one paragraph

All 50 questions per paper are compulsory, objective-type MCQs. In 2026 a total of 332 question papers were administered across the exam's 35 shifts - including 996 papers in multiple languages - totalling 18,160 questions. The style rewards precision: four options, +5 for the right one, -1 for a wrong one, and 72 seconds a question. Practise with that clock from day one, even in untimed chapter-wise tests; the discipline of the format is trainable and cumulative.

CHAPTER 9

Domain Spotlights: What Each Paper Rewards

Thirteen of the most-chosen domain papers, one study directive each - all on the NCERT base.

Every domain paper below is built on the same NCERT Class 12 syllabus your board follows. What differs is the way the MCQ format interrogates that syllabus. Use these spotlights to shape how you study each subject - not as a substitute for the syllabus itself, which lives on cuet.nta.nic.in's subject pages.

The science block

Physics (322)

The paper lives on concepts, derivations and numerical applications. Master every NCERT solved example - MCQs are frequently those examples wearing different numbers. Keep a single formula sheet from day one, redraw every diagram from memory, and drill unit-wise numericals with a stopwatch; the 72-second clock bites hardest in Physics.

Chemistry (306)

The most fact-dense of the three. Physical chemistry is numerical and formula-driven; inorganic is pure recall - trends, exceptions, named reactions, coordination compounds; organic rewards mechanism-level understanding rather than memorised equations. Assertion-reason style items thrive here: practise answering 'why', not just 'what', for every NCERT line.

Biology family (304)

Volume recall under a strict clock: terminology, definitions, diagrams and the NCERT's own summaries. Reproduction, genetics and biotechnology carry heavy concept load; the diagrams are scoring machines if you practise drawing them quickly. Self-testing beats re-reading for this paper more than for any other.

Mathematics / Applied Mathematics (319)

The application skill of the whole exam. Calculus, algebra and vectors dominate the Class 12 syllabus; speed comes from archetype practice - recognising the question type in the first five seconds. NCERT exemplar-level difficulty is the right band; grind miscellanies and previous papers under time, not just solutions.

The commerce block

Accountancy / Book-Keeping (301)

Calculation speed and format discipline: journal entries, ledgers, financial statements, partnership and company accounts. Every NCERT illustration should be re-solved by hand, timed - the paper is generous to the accurate and brutal to the slow. Keep a formats notebook; MCQs often test 'which entry is correct' where speed of pattern recognition decides.

Business Studies (305)

Theory with application: management principles, business environment, marketing, financial management. Case-based MCQs dominate, so convert every chapter into keyword-level recall pages and practise applying principles to short scenarios. Among the most efficient papers to consolidate late - and the easiest to underestimate in September.

Economics / Business Economics (309)

Split personality: micro and macro concepts plus numericals (national income, elasticity, money and banking). NCERT plus regular practice of graph-based and calculation-based MCQs covers the demand; the trap is reading economics like history - it is a diagram-and-formula subject in MCQ clothing.

The humanities block**History (314)**

Dates, causes, sources and themes - the NCERT's thematic structure is the map. Build timelines per theme (national movement, world wars, cultural processes) and practise source-based MCQs, since the paper tests interpretation of passages and maps, not just recall.

Political Science (323)

Contemporary world politics plus Indian constitution and politics. Definitions, articles, landmark judgements and current-adjacent polity facts; this paper pairs naturally with GAT current-affairs preparation, which is one reason the two make a powerful combination in your five.

Geography / Geology (313)

Human geography dominates: population, settlements, resources, industries. Maps and data interpretation are scoring and trainable; keep an atlas habit alongside NCERT chapters.

Psychology (324)

Concepts, thinkers, disorders and methods - precise vocabulary decides marks. Assertion-reason style questions are common, so test yourself on distinctions between similar-sounding terms rather than definitions alone.

Sociology (326) and Mass Media (318)

Sociology rewards structure-based recall - institutions, thinkers, processes - turned into concept cards. Mass Media blends theory with current examples; anchor it to a monthly media-current-affairs note. Both map to fewer university courses than the big five - check your grid before spending a slot.

Computer Science / Information Practices (308)

For the programming-inclined: NCERT-level Python basics, database fundamentals and networking concepts in MCQ form. Trace code on paper, by hand, quickly - that is the entire exam skill.

One directive that applies to all thirteen

Whatever the subject, your final month should run only on three inputs: your one-page chapter summaries, past-paper and question-bank MCQs under time, and the error log. If a study plan does not feed one of those three, it is decoration.

CHAPTER 10

The General Aptitude Playbook

The one paper nobody's board syllabus covers - and where ranks are quietly made.

Because every other paper overlaps your board preparation, the GAT is the only genuinely new 250 marks in your CUET account. In 2026 the GAT was among the five most-chosen subjects in the entire exam. Here is how to prepare each official component without wasting a single weekend.

GAT component (official)	What it means in practice	Weekly habit that works
General knowledge	Static GK: polity, geography, history, science basics, books-awards-sports	One focused GK source, 30 minutes daily; a running notes page per theme
Current affairs	National and international events of the past 12 months	One daily news digest read consistently; monthly 1-page recap written by you
General mental ability	Series, coding-decoding, analogies, odd-one-out	Two 20-question timed sets weekly
Numerical ability	Percentages, ratios, averages, time-speed-distance, basic arithmetic	Daily 15-minute drill; error log for every miss
Quantitative reasoning	Simple applications of arithmetic, algebra, geometry, mensuration, statistics	NCERT-level basics, then applied MCQs; formulas on one sheet
Logical & analytical reasoning	Arrangements, syllogisms, blood relations, direction sense, data-based puzzles	One worked set daily, fully analysed, not just attempted

The current-affairs window that matters

Current affairs are typically tested from roughly a year before the exam - for a May 2027 exam, prepare from mid-2026 onward. The efficient method is a single reliable daily source plus your own monthly summary notes; switching sources every month is the classic way to read a lot and retain nothing. Static GK compounds slowly and is best attached to current events (read a news story, spend four minutes on the geography or polity behind it).

Why the GAT is the highest-leverage paper in your portfolio

- Every candidate starts near zero - no one inherits it from board prep, so the field is flat.
- It improves with small daily inputs rather than long sittings - the easiest paper to prepare alongside boards.
- Its score multiplies across universities: for many programmes it is the second or the only merit paper.
- Reasoning and numerical ability are trainable to near-full accuracy - among the most reliable 200+ marks in the exam.

Start it this week, in 40 minutes

Monday to Saturday: 15 minutes of numerical drill + 15 minutes of one reasoning set + 10 minutes of current affairs. Sunday: write one page of the week's current affairs from memory, then check it. That is under five hours a week - and by January you will have an eight-month habit that most of your competition never builds.

CHAPTER 11

Your First Seven Days

A concrete week-one plan - because momentum is a system, not a mood.

Everything in this book can start this week. Here is exactly what to do on each of the next seven days, in about an hour a day, so that by Sunday you have a subject portfolio, a university list, a GAT habit and your first timed questions behind you.

Day	The one-hour task
Day 1	Write down 5-8 target courses (not colleges) across your three tiers. Pull the CUET subject mapping for the two most important ones from cuet.nta.nic.in .
Day 2	Build the Chapter 7 grid: courses down the side, required subjects across the top. Circle the subjects that cover the most target courses.
Day 3	Draft your five subjects. Sleep on it; show it to one person who has actually read a university bulletin - a teacher, a senior, not a random forum.
Day 4	List your domain subjects' NCERT chapters on one page per subject; mark which are done, half-done, untouched. That page is your syllabus dashboard for the next three months.
Day 5	Start the GAT habit: 15 minutes numerical drill + 15 minutes one reasoning set + 10 minutes current affairs. Set a fixed daily time slot - same slot, every day.
Day 6	Buy or download the official resources: NCERT texts (ncert.nic.in offers free PDFs), one MCQ question bank per domain subject, and bookmark NTA mock portals + SATHEE CUET.
Day 7	Take one timed 60-minute paper - any domain subject, chapter-mixed. Do not study for it; the purpose is to meet the 72-second clock. Log your first error-log entries.

By the end of this week you will have something most CUET candidates never build before February: a deliberate subject portfolio, a visible syllabus map, a running daily habit, and a baseline score to beat. Everything after this is repetition of the loop - concepts, recall pages, timed MCQs, error log - scaled up on the Chapter 17 runway.

CHAPTER 14

The Universities You Are Playing For

Two hundred and seventy-five doors, one key - so shortlist with a method, not a ranking app.

Around 275 universities accept CUET UG scores for 2027 admissions - about 49-50 central, 36 state, 25-30 deemed, over 120 private, and a handful of other government institutions. The central block is the core: every central university admits its UG students through CUET, from Aligarh Muslim University and Assam University Silchar through Banaras Hindu University, Jamia Millia Islamia, JNU, the University of Delhi and the Central University of Tamil Nadu. The state block includes Delhi Technological University, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar University Delhi, Devi Ahilya Vishwavidyalaya Indore and Dibrugarh University; the private block includes Ashoka, Chandigarh, Galgotias, Sharda and many more.

The names that anchor most candidates' lists

University	Known for (UG through CUET)
University of Delhi	The largest CUET consumer - 70+ colleges, 79 programmes and over 71,000 seats in 2026; BA/B.Com/B.Sc (Hons) of every kind
Banaras Hindu University	One of the widest programme menus in India - arts, science, commerce, agriculture, performing arts
Jawaharlal Nehru University	Languages and social sciences; the destination for BA programmes in foreign languages
Jamia Millia Islamia	Strong professional and interdisciplinary UG programmes
Aligarh Muslim University	A broad classic UG portfolio across faculties
University of Allahabad	Large traditional arts and science intake
Tezpur / Hyderabad Central / others	Strong regional centrals with respected UG departments
Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Univ. Delhi / GGSIPU	The state-university pick for Delhi-NCR candidates

How to build a three-tier list in one evening

- Tier 1 (dream):** programmes where last year's admitted scores were comfortably above your current mock level. Two to three courses, maximum.
- Tier 2 (match):** programmes at your current level. This tier deserves the most research - seats, reservations, hostel policy, actual course content.
- Tier 3 (safety):** programmes you would genuinely attend if Tiers 1-2 fall through - not ones you would sulk about. State and private CUET universities are the natural Tier 3.

Verify each entry against the university's own Bulletin of Information for the current cycle - seats, eligibility and subject mapping change year to year. A shortlist that survives re-verification in January is worth more than a long one copied from a Telegram group in June.

Delhi University, specifically

DU is where the largest share of CUET candidates land. Its admission machinery (CSAS) has its own quirks - programme-specific merit from defined paper combinations, preference filling across college-programme pairs, and spot rounds with mandatory acceptance. Chapter 21 walks the entire pipeline. If DU is anywhere on your list, read that chapter twice.

CHAPTER 13

Registration: The January Window

The form is where seasons quietly die. Open once, fill slowly, submit early.

What the 2026 cycle looked like

The 2026 form opened on 3 January and was originally to close on 30 January, with fee payment until 31 January and a correction window on 2-4 February; extensions pushed the fee deadline into early February. Only one application is allowed - the bulletin warns that multiple forms lead to cancellation of the result. Registration, form filling, document upload and fee payment are all online at cuet.nta.nic.in; no offline mode exists.

The four steps on the portal

- 1 **Registration:** name, date of birth and contact details generate your application number. Use your own email and mobile - NTA communicates only on the contacts you enter, and admit-card-stage problems surface on them.
- 2 **Form filling:** personal details, address, qualification, chosen exam cities in order of preference, and the big one - your subjects (up to five, with codes from Chapter 6).
- 3 **Document upload:** photograph and signature in the sizes the bulletin specifies - a rejected photo in the final week is a self-inflicted crisis.
- 4 **Fee payment:** online only - net banking, credit/debit card, UPI or wallets, through the banks NTA lists. Processing charges and GST apply on top. The confirmation page generates only after successful payment; keep it, print it, save it twice.

The ten mistakes that cost real candidates their seasons

- Filling the form in the last 48 hours, then hitting a payment failure with no time to recover.
- Choosing subjects before reading any university mapping - the Chapter 7 mistake, in registration form.
- Entering an email or phone number that belongs to a parent and then losing access to it.
- Wrong category claim - especially OBC-NCL claimed without checking the central list (see Chapter 14).
- Uploading a photograph taken years ago or in the wrong dimensions.
- Typing a name that does not match the Class 10 certificate exactly, letter for letter.
- Filling exam-city preferences carelessly, then being reallocated to a distant city.
- Submitting two forms 'to correct a mistake' - which cancels the result outright.
- Not using the correction window (2-4 February in 2026) to fix the one field that was wrong.
- Assuming the confirmation page generation is optional - no payment, no candidate.

The verify-the-next-day habit

After submitting, log in the next day and read every field of your form once more, slowly. Nearly every registration error is visible to a calm second read. This five-minute ritual is the cheapest insurance in the entire CUET process.

CHAPTER 14**Fees and Category Rules**

The 2026 fee table, and the category paperwork that decides far more than the fee.

Fees scale with the number of subjects you choose: a base fee covers up to three subjects, and each additional subject (fourth and fifth) costs extra. The 2026 table, which 2027 is expected to broadly follow (confirm in the January bulletin):

Category	Up to 3 subjects	Each additional subject
General (UR)	Rs. 1,000	Rs. 400
OBC-NCL (central list) / EWS	Rs. 900	Rs. 375
SC / ST / PwBD / Third Gender	Rs. 800	Rs. 350
Centres outside India	Rs. 4,500	Rs. 1,800

So a General-category candidate taking five subjects in 2026 paid Rs. 1,000 + 400 + 400 = Rs. 1,800; the same portfolio for an SC candidate was Rs. 800 + 350 + 350 = Rs. 1,500. Payment runs through the listed banks and gateways with processing charges and GST on top. Fees are non-refundable once paid.

The OBC-NCL rule that trips thousands every year

The bulletin is categorical: OBC-NCL means the central list maintained by the National Commission for Backward Classes (ncbc.nic.in). Candidates whose caste appears only in a state list - and not in the central list - must apply as General/Unreserved. Claiming OBC-NCL without central-list coverage is not a technicality; it is grounds for cancellation at document verification, after you have already won a seat on that basis. EWS claims similarly rest on the central government's income-and-asset criteria, certified for the correct year.

Reservation, in one clean paragraph

Central educational institutions reserve seats per constitutional categories (SC, ST, OBC-NCL, EWS, and PwBD with horizontal reservation), while state and private universities follow their own applicable rules. What changes with category at the exam level is only the fee and eligibility relaxations where a university grants them; what changes at admission is the seat matrix. Your category certificate must be in the exact format the university's bulletin specifies, issued by the competent authority, current for the admission year. Get this done in autumn, not in June.

Beyond the exam fee, budget for the university's own fees

Each university charges its own application fee at admission - Delhi University's CSAS fee in 2026 was Rs. 250 (UR/OBC-NCL/EWS) or Rs. 100 (SC/ST/PwBD), with additional charges for certain programmes and the ECA/Sports quotas. A multi-university season has a real, if modest, total cost: exam fee plus every university portal you seriously use.

CHAPTER 17

The Money Math of Guessing

With +5 and -1, guessing is not gambling - it is arithmetic. Here is the exact arithmetic.

Every CUET question offers four options. Correct earns +5; incorrect costs -1; blank costs nothing. From these five numbers, the entire attempt strategy follows - and it is the opposite of the JEE-style folklore most coaching advice carries over. With a one-fifth penalty, CUET's negative marking is mild by design.

The expected value of a guess

If a question has four options and you know nothing at all, each option has a 25% chance of being right. The expected value of a blind guess is $(25\% \times 5) - (75\% \times 1) = 1.25 - 0.75 = +0.50$ marks. In plain terms: a fully blind guess is not a losing play in CUET, unlike in exams with heavier penalties. If you can eliminate even one option, the expected value rises to $(33\% \times 5) - (67\% \times 1) = +1.0$. Eliminate two, and it is $(50\% \times 5) - (50\% \times 1) = +2.0$.

Your state on a question	Math	Expected value	The play
Know it	-	+5.00	Answer, fast
Two options eliminated	$50\% \times 5 - 50\% \times 1$	+2.00	Guess
One option eliminated	$33\% \times 5 - 67\% \times 1$	+1.00	Guess if time allows
Know nothing	$25\% \times 5 - 75\% \times 1$	+0.50	Guess at the end, never mid-paper
Cannot even read it in time	-	0.00 or worse	Skip

The two conditions the arithmetic hides

- **Time is the real currency.** A +0.50 guess that costs 90 seconds steals time from a +5 question you could have answered later. Blind guessing belongs to the final two minutes, on the questions you marked and parked - never as a mid-paper habit.
- **Guessing cannot repair a syllabus gap.** Expected value helps at the margins of a well-prepared paper; across a whole unprepared chapter it merely softens the damage. Study first, guess second.

The discipline that beats the math: accuracy on attempted questions

Track one number through your entire preparation: accuracy on attempted questions. A candidate attempting 42 at 90% accuracy scores $42 \times 0.9 \times 5 - 42 \times 0.1 \times 1 = 189 - 4.2 =$ about 185. A candidate attempting all 50 at 65% accuracy scores $162.5 - 17.5 = 145$. Same paper, forty marks apart - the difference is not boldness, it is precision. Your error log (Chapter 19) exists to raise exactly this number.

The rule of thumb to carry into the hall

Attempt every question you are at least half-sure of. Park true mysteries. In the last two minutes, guess the parked ones with whatever elimination survives. Then stop - do not arbitrage the review screen into new errors.

CHAPTER 16**Boards + CUET: One Syllabus, Two Exams**

NCERT is the shared syllabus. The exam formats are different sports - train both, once.

The single most relieving fact in this book: the domain-subject half of CUET is drawn from the same NCERT syllabus you must master for your board exams. The work is shared. What is not shared is the format - boards reward long written answers, CUET rewards fast, precise MCQs with negative marking. Preparing for both is one syllabus trained two ways, not two syllabi.

Dimension	Class 12 boards	CUET domain papers
Syllabus	NCERT	Same NCERT
Format	Descriptive, step-marked	50 compulsory MCQs
Marking	No negative marking	+5 / -1
Clock	3 hours, generous	60 minutes, ~72 seconds a question
What it rewards	Depth of written explanation	Speed, precision, concept application
Result used for	Qualifying exam + eligibility	University admission merit

The sequence that makes both exams one project

- 1 Concepts first, from NCERT, properly:** read the chapter, work the examples and exercises, and be able to explain the idea in your own words. This serves boards and CUET identically - there is no version of CUET success on top of shallow concepts.
- 2 Convert notes to recall formats:** one-page chapter summaries, formula sheets, diagram redrawing, definition cards. Board answers need elaboration; CUET needs instant retrieval - the summary serves both.
- 3 Layer MCQ practice on top:** after each chapter, solve a timed MCQ set on it - NCERT exemplar-style questions, previous-year CUET papers, and a good question bank. This is the CUET-specific layer, thin and frequent.
- 4 Train the clock monthly:** from November, one 60-minute full-paper simulation per subject per month; from February, weekly (Chapter 17).

Board students from CBSE boards have the closest syllabus overlap with the NCERT base; ICSE, state-board and other students should expect a mapping period - find the NCERT chapters your board does not cover and the reverse, and budget a few alignment weeks in October-November rather than pretending the gap does not exist.

One honest warning about February

Pre-board exams collide with CUET's prime mock season. That collision is manageable if you have been layering MCQs since October - pre-boards themselves become revision. It is brutal if CUET practice starts in February, which is the default mistake this entire chapter exists to prevent.

CHAPTER 17**The September-to-May Runway**

Eight months, three phases, every month with a job - the spine of your preparation.

From September 2026 to the expected May 2027 window you have roughly eight months. The plan below assumes you attend school full-time; it is built around 2-3 focused CUET hours a day on weekdays and more on weekends, with the GAT habit of Chapter 10 running in parallel throughout.

Phase	Months	The one job of this phase
Build	Sept - Nov 2026	Finish NCERT concept work for all domain subjects + language reading habit + daily GAT habit running
Consolidate	Dec 2026 - Feb 2027	Complete the syllabus' second pass as MCQs; register flawlessly in January; survive pre-boards using CUET revision
Rehearse	Mar - May 2027	Weekly full-length mocks, error-log-driven patching, current-affairs recap, exam-week taper

A sample week during the Build phase

Day	Domain work (the deep block)	GAT + language (the daily block)
Mon-Fri	90 minutes split across two domain subjects: 60 concepts + 30 timed MCQs on today's chapters	40-minute GAT habit + 20 minutes reading in your CUET language
Saturday	3-hour deep block on the weakest domain subject + a 30-question weekly test	Full GAT habit + one timed comprehension set
Sunday	2 hours: error-log review + writing the week's recall pages	One page of the week's current affairs from memory, then rest

Build: September to November 2026

- Week by week, one domain subject leads while others get maintenance revision; finish the NCERT first pass for your heaviest subject before Diwali.
- Start the GAT habit in week one (Chapter 10) - it is the only phase in which it is painless to start.
- Build the Chapter 7 subject grid and the three-tier university list; finalise your intended five subjects by end October (re-verify in January).
- Read 20-30 minutes daily in your CUET language, across genres; it compounds like nothing else.

Consolidate: December 2026 to February 2027

- Convert every completed chapter into one-page recall notes; second pass = chapter-wise MCQs, not re-reading.

- January: register in the form's first week (not its last), using the documents list from Chapter 4; use the correction window for a final field-by-field read.
- Pre-boards: treat them as full syllabus revision; keep only the daily GAT habit alive through them.
- From February: one full-length mock per week per major subject, with the error log running (Chapter 19).

Rehearse: March to May 2027

- Mocks twice a week; each mock fully analysed the same day - an unanalysed mock is entertainment.
- April: revise from your one-page summaries only; refresh current affairs from mid-2026 forward; do the free NTA/SATHEE computer mocks to normalise the interface.
- Exam weeks (likely May): follow NTA's city and admit-card notices closely; keep every acknowledgement safe.
- Final fortnight: no new topics; sleep schedule aligned to your shift times; formulas, maps and error-log revision only.

If you are starting late

Starting in November or December, cut Build to a compressed 8 weeks by triaging NCERT chapters against question frequency in past papers, and merge the first two passes. Starting in February still works for NCERT-strong students - but only with daily timed MCQs from day one and the GAT habit running. What never works is 'starting after boards'.

CHAPTER 20

Stream Playbooks: Science, Commerce, Humanities

Same exam, same NCERT base - but each stream's score risks live in different places.

Science students

- Your domain papers (Physics, Chemistry, Biology/Mathematics) are the deepest overlap with boards - and also the most-chosen papers in the exam (Chemistry, Physics and Mathematics were among the top five subjects by registration in 2026), so expect dense marking and real competition.
- Many science candidates are simultaneously running JEE or NEET preparation. The concept base transfers; what does not transfer is the paper itself - NCERT-level fact questions (especially in Chemistry and Biology), diagram-based items and NCERT exemplar-style MCQs need CUET-specific drills that entrance-exam prep skims past.
- The classic science trap is treating the language paper and the GAT as free marks. They are not free, they are merely cheap to prepare - see Chapters 8 and 10.

Commerce students

- Accountancy/Business Studies/Economics papers are NCERT-based and concept-plus-application; practise case-based MCQs and numericals under time pressure - accountancy especially rewards calculation speed.

- B.Com (Hons) and BA (Hons) Economics mappings at big universities commonly involve Mathematics/Applied Mathematics (code 319) - verify your target course's exact combination before dropping Maths from your five.
- Business Studies and Economics are heavily theory subjects - convert every chapter to a recall page early; they are the easiest domain papers to consolidate in the December-February window.

Humanities students

- Your domain menu is the widest - History, Political Science, Geography, Sociology, Psychology, Mass Media and more - and humanities programmes commonly admit on combinations that include the GAT, making it your second engine rather than an afterthought.
- Humanities papers reward volume recall: dates, articles, thinkers, case names, definitions. Spaced revision and self-testing beat re-reading; start the recall-page habit in October.
- For psychology and mass media aspirants, note the bundle codes (Chapter 6) and check each university's mapping carefully - these courses vary most across universities in what they demand.

The cross-stream truth

Whichever stream you come from, the exam does not care. NTA allows subjects irrespective of your Class 12 stream, and universities map courses to papers, not streams. A science student taking History for a university's mapping, or a humanities student taking Mathematics for an economics programme, is entirely legitimate - provided the preparation is real, because the paper will not respect your courage.

CHAPTER 19

Mock Tests and the Error Log

Mocks do not raise scores. Analysed mocks do. Here is the analysis system.

The cadence that works

From February 2027, one full-length 60-minute paper per major subject per week; from late March, two per week; in the final month, match your exam shift times. Before February, chapter-wise timed sets do the work - full-length mocks before the syllabus is consolidated mostly measure anxiety. Free, official-quality practice exists: NTA's mock tests and the National Testing Abhyas app, plus SATHEE CUET (sathee.iitk.ac.in), the government's free CUET preparation platform built with the IITs - use at least one computer-interface mock a fortnight throughout, because the interface itself (palette, mark-for-review, timer) is a skill.

The error log: four buckets, one line each

After every mock and every chapter test, every wrong (and every lucky-right) question goes into a running notebook or sheet, one line: date, subject, topic, and the bucket. The buckets matter more than the count:

Bucket	What it means	The fix it demands
Concept gap	You did not know the fact or idea	Back to the NCERT chapter, that day or weekend
Application slip	Knew the concept, could not apply it in the question's form	More MCQs of the same archetype
Speed miss	Knew it, ran out of time	Timed drills; question-selection practice

Bucket	What it means	The fix it demands
Careless error	Read wrong, marked wrong, calculation slip	Slow down on keywords; re-check flagged answers

Weekly, count the buckets. Concept gaps dominate until December - that is normal. From March, application and speed slips should dominate; a March log still full of concept gaps means the Build phase was skipped, and the fix is triage, not panic. Careless errors should shrink steadily to near-zero - they are the cheapest marks in the exam.

The 3:1 rule

Spend at least three units of analysis time per unit of testing time: a 60-minute mock earns a 3-hour review the same day. The candidates whose scores plateau are, almost uniformly, the ones who collect attempts instead of analyses.

CHAPTER 20

After the Exam: Scores and Answer-Key Challenges

The three weeks between your last paper and the result - and your one window to change the result.

How the result arrives

NTA publishes CUET UG scorecards on its portal - in 2026, the result was declared on 23 June, roughly three weeks after the last rescheduled paper. The scorecard reports your subject-wise scores, computed from your responses against the final answer keys. Keep the PDF saved and printed; every university admission portal will ask you to self-report these scores, and mismatches cause verification-stage trouble.

Multi-shift papers and normalisation

CUET 2026 ran 35 shifts; where the same paper is administered across shifts, NTA uses a multi-shift score compilation procedure (documented in the bulletin's appendices) so that no candidate is advantaged or penalised by shift difficulty. What you control is identical across shifts: the syllabus and the clock. Do not spend a single evening on shift strategy; spend them on the error log.

The answer-key challenge - your one intervention window

- 1 NTA displays provisional answer keys together with your recorded responses and question papers, and opens a challenge window (fee per question, refunded if your challenge is upheld).
- 2 Check every response that surprises you - transcription errors and genuinely debatable keys are real, if rare.
- 3 File challenges within the window only; nothing can be challenged after the final keys are published.
- 4 Final answer keys are then locked, and results are computed on them.

What the score is not

Your CUET scorecard carries no rank, no percentile column and no pass/fail. It is a set of subject scores. Merit positions are computed later, differently, by each university for each programme - which is why the admission phase (Chapters 21-22) is a separate campaign, with its own calendar and its own mistakes to avoid.

CHAPTER 24**From Score to Seat: DU CSAS Decoded**

Delhi University admits through a three-phase system of its own. Learn it before you need it.

Delhi University is the largest single consumer of CUET scores - in 2026 it offered more than 71,000 seats across 79 undergraduate programmes in over 70 colleges. Its admission machinery, the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS-UG), opened within days of the CUET result (27 June 2026 for a 23 June result) and ran to mid-August. Appearing in CUET is a necessary but not sufficient condition - you must separately apply on DU's CSAS portal, or you have no seat at DU, whatever your score.

The three phases

Phase	What you do	Timing (2026 pattern)
Phase I - Apply to DU	Register on the CSAS portal with your CUET application number; pay the CSAS fee (Rs. 250 for UR/OBC-NCL/EWS, Rs. 100 for SC/ST/PwBD)	Opens with the CUET result; before pre-registration closes
Phase II - Fill preferences	Enter programme + college combinations, as many as you would genuinely attend	After Phase I, per DU's schedule
Phase III - Allocation rounds	Seats are allocated by programme-specific merit; accept, verify documents, pay; or 'upgrade' to a higher preference in later rounds	Multiple rounds through July-August

How merit is computed

DU calculates a programme-specific merit score from your CUET papers using each programme's stated combination - the portal auto-computes and displays it for every programme you are eligible for, so you see your standing before you fill preferences. This is why subject choice in January (Chapter 7) determines your DU universe in June: an eligibility gap is invisible until it is fatal.

The rounds: acceptance, upgrade, freeze

- **Accept** a provisionally allocated seat before the round's deadline or lose it.
- **Upgrade:** accepting a seat does not end your candidacy - you can opt for upgrade, and later rounds consider you for higher preferences while holding your current seat.
- **Spot rounds:** after regular rounds, DU announces spot rounds for remaining vacancies. A spot-round allocation is mandatory to accept - refusing it ends your DU admission entirely, and no upgrades or withdrawals operate during spot rounds.

The documents DU verification demands

Class 10 and 12 certificates and marksheets, category certificates in the exact prescribed format, transfer and migration documents as applicable - carried to the allocated college for physical verification within the given window. Incomplete verification forfeits the seat. Assemble the folder in June, not on verification morning.

CHAPTER 25

Other Universities' Counselling

There is no national counselling after CUET. Every university is its own campaign.

The single most important sentence in this chapter: after the result, nothing happens automatically. NTA sends your scores nowhere on your behalf. Each of the 275+ participating universities runs its own admission cycle - its own portal, its own timeline, its own merit rules - and a candidate holding a strong score who applied to no portal holds nothing.

The general pattern

- 1 The university announces its UG admission notification after CUET results (large centrals typically within one to three weeks; state and private universities vary through June-August).
- 2 You register on its portal, fill programme and (where applicable) college preferences, and pay its application fee.
- 3 Merit lists are published from the university's own programme-specific combinations of your CUET papers.
- 4 Rounds of allocation, document verification and fee payment follow; many universities also run upgrade and spot rounds for vacant seats.

Your June-July calendar, planned in May

In May, while waiting for the result, list every university from your three tiers and record: portal URL, expected application window, fee, and documents demanded. When the result lands, you execute a ready plan instead of discovering deadlines after they pass. BHU, Jamia, AMU, Allahabad, Tezpur and the other centrals all publish their own bulletins - read each target's admission bulletin once, end to end, before its portal opens. No one will track these portals for you - your own one-page tracker is your counselling desk.

Three truths about this phase

- A good score applied to five well-chosen universities beats a great score applied to one dream portal.
- Category and document problems, not marks, cause most lost seats at verification - Chapter 14's paperwork discipline is the whole game here.
- Spot and later rounds genuinely fill seats every year at good universities; being out of the race in July means being unable to win it in August.

CHAPTER 23

A Note for Parents: Costs, Calendars and Scam-Proofing

What the adults in the house actually need to know - in one place, from the official record.

The real, total cost of the season

The exam itself is modest: in 2026, a General-category candidate paid Rs. 1,000 for up to three subjects plus Rs. 400 per extra subject - about Rs. 1,800 for five; reserved categories paid less (Chapter 14 has the full table). Then each university charges its own admission fee at counselling - Delhi University's CSAS fee, for example, was Rs. 250 (UR/OBC-NCL/EWS) or Rs. 100 (SC/ST/PwBD) in 2026. Budget also for question banks, possibly a mock-test series, travel to the exam city and document work (certificates, photographs, courier). A realistic all-in figure for a five-subject, multi-university season sits in low thousands of rupees - exclusive of any coaching, which this book's method does not require.

The calendar to put on the fridge

- **Now to December:** quiet build - NCERT concepts, daily habits. Nothing urgent happens; consistency is the whole job.
- **January:** registration opens (3 January in 2026). This is the month where help with documents, photos and a calm second read of the form genuinely matters.
- **February:** a short correction window, then pre-boards.
- **May:** the exam window - three weeks of possible exam days; travel and rest logistics matter.
- **Late June to August:** result, then university applications, rounds, verification and fee payments. Deadlines are short and absolute; a missed acceptance can end a seat.

Scam-proofing the household

- CUET papers are never leaked on WhatsApp, Telegram or any 'prediction' service. Every year, families lose money - and sometimes candidacy, by engaging - to exactly these claims. The official flow is always: NTA portal, admit card, exam, result.
- No paid service is required to 'guarantee' a seat or 'handle' NTA registration. The form takes under an hour with the documents from Chapter 4; filling it yourself removes the most common failure point of all.
- University admissions run only through each university's own official portal - DU's is admission.uod.ac.in. Look-alike 'admission help' sites with paid forms are a recurring trap every June.
- If a message creates urgency ('last chance today'), verify on the official website before acting. Urgency is the scammer's tool, not NTA's style.

How to actually help (and where to step back)

Help most where the stakes are administrative: document folders in autumn, a second read of the January form, travel and rest during the exam window, deadline tracking during admission rounds - a shared calendar entry on acceptance and verification dates has saved more seats than any lecture. Step back from the academic choices that belong to the candidate: the subject portfolio (Chapter 7) should be built from course mappings and the student's honest strengths, not from what a relative studied twenty years ago. The most useful sentence a parent can say in this season is short: 'what do you need from me this week?'

CHAPTER 24

Twenty Questions, Answered Straight

The questions every CUET aspirant and parent actually asks - answered from the official record.

Question	Answer
When should I start preparing for CUET 2027?	Now, in September 2026 - about eight months before the expected May 2027 window. NCERT-heavy domain papers and the GAT both reward early, steady accumulation; January starters can still do well, but they sacrifice the mock season to syllabus panic.
Is CUET harder than board exams?	Different, not harder. The syllabus is the same NCERT, but the format - 50 compulsory MCQs in 60 minutes with +5/-1 marking - punishes slow recall and half-knowledge in a way board descriptive papers do not.
Is NCERT enough for the domain papers?	For concept coverage, NCERT is the stated syllabus base and the right spine. But NCERT alone gives you no MCQ practice, no timing, no negative-marking discipline - a question bank and past papers layered on top are essential, not optional.
Can I choose subjects I did not study in Class 12?	Yes - NTA explicitly permits subject choice irrespective of your Class 12 subjects. Your constraint is each university's course mapping, not NTA's permission.
Is there negative marking?	Yes: +5 per correct answer, -1 per incorrect answer, and zero for unattempted questions. Chapter 15 shows why this makes guessing a mild-positive play when done selectively.
How many subjects should I take?	Up to five are allowed; take the four or five your target-course grid requires - and no more for prestige. Each extra paper is a full 250-mark exam to prepare and sit.
Is there an age limit or attempt limit?	No age limit for appearing in CUET (UG). NTA sets no attempt cap either; eligibility is ultimately about each university's programme rules.
How many times can I sit CUET?	There is no stated attempt limit - candidates who completed Class 12 in earlier years sit openly, and the result is accepted by universities per their own eligibility rules for the programme.
Which language paper should I choose?	The one your target programmes map (many accept any of the 13) and the one you read fastest in. Comprehension speed - not literary pride - is what scores.
Is coaching necessary?	No. NCERT + a question bank + past papers + the free official platforms (NTA mocks, National Testing Abhyas, SATHEE CUET) + the error-log method cover everything a course sells. What coaching provides that self-study lacks is structure and accountability - this handbook's plan is that structure.
What is the GAT and why does everyone say don't skip it?	The General Aptitude Test - GK, current affairs, mental ability, numerical ability, quantitative reasoning and logical reasoning. It is the only paper with no board-exam overlap, so it is where preparation time converts most directly into rank advantage (Chapter 10).
How much does CUET cost?	In 2026: Rs. 1,000 base (General) for up to three subjects, plus Rs. 400 per additional subject; lower for reserved categories; far higher for overseas centres. Then each university charges its own admission fee.
Can I change my subjects after registering?	Only through the correction window NTA opens briefly after registration closes (2-4 February in 2026), and only for fields NTA permits - which is why Chapter 7's grid work happens in September, not in panic.
What if two of my papers clash in the same shift?	NTA schedules subjects across the multi-week window to avoid clashes within your chosen set; the allocation is communicated with your admit card and advance exam-city notice. Report any genuine conflict to the NTA helpline immediately rather than assuming.

Question	Answer
Is the exam online or on paper?	Fully computer-based (CBT) at allocated centres - 321 cities in 2026, including 15 international. Practise on a screen; paper habits do not transfer for free.
When do CUET 2027 registrations open?	Expected in early January 2027, following the 3 January 2026 pattern - announced when NTA releases the 2027 Information Bulletin on cet.nta.nic.in . That bulletin is the final word on everything in this book.
Do universities see my board marks along with my CUET score?	They see what they ask you to report, and most centrals primarily use CUET-based programme merit - but many programmes carry their own qualifying-exam minimums. Board marks remain an eligibility gate even where they are not a merit gate; treat them accordingly.
Can I use one CUET score at multiple universities?	Yes - that is the entire design. One score, 275+ doors, each with its own separate application in its own window. Chapter 22's tracker is how you miss none of them.
What happens after the result?	Nothing automatic - you apply to each university's own admission process (DU's CSAS, BHU's portal, and so on). Chapters 21-22 are that campaign's manual.
What if I don't get the score I wanted?	Use the spot rounds and late university cycles first - real seats close every August. Beyond that: CUET has no attempt limit, the syllabus is the NCERT you already know, and the GAT habit is even stronger the second year. A planned gap year with a January retake of your strategy - not just your syllabus - is a legitimate path.

CHAPTER 25

The Master Checklist and Official Sources

The whole season as tick-boxes - and where every fact in this book comes from.

September-November 2026 (Build)

- Subject grid built from current university mappings; intended five subjects finalised
- NCERT first pass under way for all domain subjects; recall pages started
- Daily GAT habit running (15 + 15 + 10 minutes)
- Daily 20-30 minutes reading in your CUET language
- Three-tier university list drafted

December-February 2027 (Consolidate + Register)

- Chapter-wise MCQ conversion under way; documents folder assembled
- 2027 Information Bulletin read cover-to-cover on release day; changes noted against this book
- Registration submitted in the form's first week; verification re-read the next day; correction window used if needed
- Fee paid; confirmation page saved twice
- Pre-boards treated as revision; weekly full-length mocks begun by late February

March-May 2027 (Rehearse)

- Two mocks weekly per major subject, each fully analysed into the error log
- Current affairs recap from mid-2026 onward; computer-interface mocks on NTA/SATHEE platforms

- Exam city and admit card notices tracked; printouts and ID ready
- Final fortnight: summaries, formulas and error log only; sleep aligned to shift times

June-August 2027 (Admission campaign)

- Result downloaded and self-reported accurately on every portal
- Answer-key challenge window used where warranted
- University tracker executed: every target portal applied to within days of opening
- DU CSAS preferences filled generously; rounds tracked to the end, including spot rounds
- Documents folder carried to every verification, complete and in order

Official sources behind this handbook

- cuet.nta.nic.in - the CUET (UG) portal: bulletins, syllabus pages, participating-university lists, notices
- nta.ac.in - National Testing Agency notices and press releases, including the 2026 conduct and result data
- admission.uod.ac.in / ugadmission.uod.ac.in - Delhi University CSAS (UG) portal, Bulletin of Information and schedules
- ncbc.nic.in - the central OBC list that governs OBC-NCL claims
- sathee.iitk.ac.in - SATHEE CUET, the free Government of India CUET preparation platform

Data notes: registration and conduct figures (15,68,866 registered; 11,64,098 appeared; 321 cities; 868 Indian centres; 19 days; 35 shifts; 332 papers; 18,160 questions) are from NTA's official 2026 press releases and statistics. Fees, dates, pattern, subjects and eligibility rules are from the CUET (UG) 2026 Information Bulletin and official FAQs. DU CSAS details are from the University of Delhi's official CSAS documents. Everything dated 2027 in this book is a clearly-marked expectation anchored to the 2026 cycle. When the 2027 bulletin arrives, it wins.

One last page, said plainly

CUET is a fair exam in a way few Indian exams are: one syllabus everyone already owns (NCERT), one paper format you can rehearse for months, and no ceiling on attempts. The students who win it are not the ones with secret materials; they are the ones who started in September, chose subjects against the mapping tables, finished the NCERT base, layered a thousand timed MCQs on top, and then executed the admission season like a checklist. That is the whole game. Go play it.

THE CUET UG 2027 STARTER HANDBOOK

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Thank you for reading. Wishing you a calm, well-planned season and the seat you are working for.